

The Strategist is Me

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1 Notion before $\rightarrow$ Strategist = Analytical Strength

Before this course, I thought a strategist was someone who saw the board more clearly than everyone else. Same board, same pieces, same rules — but a sharper eye, a longer horizon, a better next move. I thought strategy was primarily (and mostly) a function of analytical strength. Like when everybody else was looking at the current move only, the strategist was looking three moves ahead.

Now I think that **this view was flat and very restricted**. It assumed the board itself was given. It treated strategy as selection on a fixed surface (same domain). And it proposed the strategist's edge entirely in the quality of his attention, never in the direction of it.

2 I call it 2D's $\rightarrow$ Dimension & Depth

The notion I now hold about strategy has two parts, and neither works without the other.

It starts with looking at different **Dimensions** of the problem, OR ways of finding **potential solution space**. This approach though can bring us very close to the solution but the real actionable insight can only be gained from **Depth** in that respective solution space.

2.1 Dimension

Dimension is a shift in perspective of how we look at the current situation AND the path to reach solution. **A strategist's edge does not come from looking harder at what everyone else is looking at; it comes from looking somewhere else entirely**. The four Cs, for me, are four demonstrations of this single move.

Contrast taught me to challenge institutional, conformist approaches. **Combination** taught me to design a decision chain rather than a single unit work. **Constraints** taught me to look at the environment rather than the actor, because behavior is downstream of design. **Context** taught me to look outside the domain entirely, because importing foreign concepts makes a difference once we hit the current domain's limits.

2.2 Depth

The second part is **depth** which comes into picture when we have landed in the **"Potential Solution Space"** using Dimension(the first D). A dimension of problem, on its own, is just a set of perspectives; and **perspectives are vital but still cheap**. What makes a non-obvious angle strategically valuable is the access to its fundamental structural layer where the real causes live. By analyzing this depth we can find/craft the final actionable strategy.

2.3 My Notion

Now I know that a strategist works several levels below the information layer, and more closer to the actual problem. So my notion of a strategist now is $\rightarrow$ **someone who chooses to look at a situation's numerous dimensions for finding prospective directions & then goes in depth with a utilitarian and first principle thinking approach to find and craft an actionable strategy plan**.

The first move is creative(something that this course has taught me) while the second one is disciplined. Together it makes a **framework which is induced by Creativity & First Principle Thinking at its very core and then becomes more powerful when paired up with depth**.

3 Strategy in Software & AI

Despite being a CS student, I have always loved studying strategy, conflict management, and negotiation, and I have constantly applied these in my personal and professional life.

I am keen on applying these learnings across all aspects of life, but actively in problem-solving in computer science **while building scalable software and commercial AI systems**.

As I know that engineering culture rewards complexity, rolling-out features and raised metrics, I know I don't have to fall prey for this traps.

- Now my instinct is to first **refuse or question the obvious framing of the problem** and think which **C or Dimension** we need to progress along to effectively find the solution.
- Once shortlisted, I can drill down on those fronts until I find the root cause and develop the solution mechanism.
- This will help me in reviewing system designs, where my focus will not be on “Which option is better?” but “What solves the problem efficiently?”, since an **empirically superior option is not always the best-fit solution**.
- This will also help me understand problems like rising user churn, which is not always about demanding new features but can be about latent leaks in the end-to-end user experience.

4 Constant Recalibration

I can see myself slipping into the following failure states while following my current notion. Noticing and correcting these is essential as it is the very mechanism by which I plan to keep refining my thinking frameworks.

Over-engineering: Sometimes the obvious view is correct, and reaching for a non-obvious angle is just intellectual vanity. **Time Restriction:** Some situations reward speed, not structure. A strategist who always drills to the mechanism becomes a philosopher with a backlog.

I plan to refine this notion through practice over time, via **Live Analysis as well as Retrospection**.

1. I need to constantly **keep a tab** on whether I am over-engineering and inventing depth that the situation does not contain. I also need to mold my framework based on the incentives of the problem at hand.
2. Once done with events I need to **ask myself** whether the perspectives I chose were sufficient and whether the structural layer I identified was actually the **causal** one.

The framework that survives that record is mine. Rest of the parts will be recalibrated.

References & Acknowledgements

1. Use of AI: Initial Draft.
2. I loved this course and has been my favorite course from NYU.

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